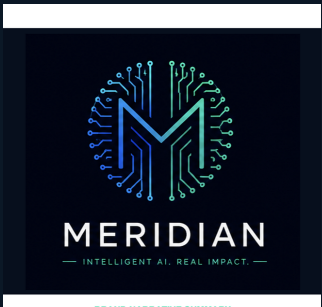




Meridian, Velocity, Ambrion

Three Businesses, Three Front Doors, One Portfolio

Answering Shane McCarthy’s challenge of 4 August 2026
Decision taken by John, 5 August 2026: Meridian is the decision brief

PRIVATE AND CONFIDENTIAL

THE ONE LINE THAT DIVIDES THEM

Ambrion makes you compliant. Velocity makes you capable. Meridian makes the call.
Three different buyers, three different questions, three different rooms. Only one of them is a choice. Ambrion’s buyer is compelled by law. Velocity’s buyer has already decided AI is the answer. Meridian’s buyer is standing in front of an open decision that has nothing to do with AI.

	MERIDIAN INTELLIGENCE	VELOCITY AI	AMBRION AI
What it is	Executive intelligence practice	AI operator and builder	AI strategy, architecture and governance firm
What it sells	A decision	AI capability, built and deployed	Done-for-you EU AI Act compliance, tiered
The buyer’s actual question	“Should I do this, and what will it cost me if I am wrong?”	“How do I get AI into this business?”	“The EU AI Act applies to us now. Are we compliant?”
Is the buyer thinking about AI?	No. They are thinking about a deal, a valuation, an investor, an audit	Yes. Already decided AI is the question	Yes, and usually because the law made them
Who they are	Owner, chair, board of a mid-market business facing one high-consequence decision	Executive team committing to an AI programme	Irish SME owners and boards inside EU AI Act scope
The room	The room where the decision is made	The room where the programme is built	The compliance and board oversight conversation
Product	Written, decision-grade position. Days, not weeks	Two-phase transformation programme. Months	Tiered done-for-you compliance, plus executive AI training
Verified pricing	Indicative only, see business case	€30,000 + VAT Phase One, 3 months, at €10,000/month (EDelia, June 2026)	Tiered. Rates not yet on record

	MERIDIAN INTELLIGENCE	VELOCITY AI	AMBRION AI
Lead / front door	John, personally	Shane	Shane CEO and architect. John commercial and governance lead
Ownership	John 70 / Shane 30	Shane 70 / John 30	UNCONFIRMED, the only remaining gap
Route to market	John's board relationships, direct	Direct, plus site diagnostics	Smacht network, c.300 Irish SMEs via Padraic O'Maille. Accountants and solicitors as referral partners. UHL training
Time to value	Days	Months	Weeks to months
Portfolio priority	Complementary, and the upstream feeder	Shane-led build arm	John's primary revenue vehicle for the next three years
What it leaves behind	A decision made properly, and the reasoning on file	Built systems, proof points, embedded orchestration	A compliance position that survives regulatory scrutiny

Read across the top row again

The single most important row is “is the buyer thinking about AI.” Velocity’s and Ambrion’s buyers are. Meridian’s buyer is not.

Anthony Hennessy was thinking about gas cylinders. John Lynch was thinking about what his business is worth. Fleming Medical’s board was thinking about a capital event. Johnny Shanahan was thinking about a fifty thousand pound investor. United Hardware’s ARC was thinking about whether an audit was sound. None of them wanted AI. All of them wanted an answer.

That is why Meridian does not compete with Velocity or Ambrion. It reaches a buyer neither of them can reach, at a moment neither of them is present for.

MERIDIAN INTELLIGENCE — THE DEFINITION

What it is. An **executive intelligence practice**. Its product is the decision brief. It takes one high-consequence business decision and returns a written, decision-grade position in days, using seven senior domains run simultaneously over the same question, with forty years of board-level judgment as the final gate.

It is not an AI company. It is an intelligence practice that operates a governed AI engine. The client buys the answer. The engine room is Meridian's business, not theirs. This was the settled position on 31 July and is reaffirmed here.

The four situations it is bought for, all evidenced by delivered work

- 1. A capital event.** Raising, selling, taking an investor, choosing an instrument. *Barber Republic, Fleming Medical, Arcade Trader.*
- 2. A category or expansion move.** Should we enter this, buy this, form this. *Stargas cylinder testing, United Hardware paint buying group, United Hardware garden centre.*
- 3. A governance question with teeth.** Audit soundness, directors' exposure, vendor challenge. *United Hardware ARC, 2025 audit review.*
- 4. A proposition that needs verifying before it is backed.** *UroPharma, Mike Molloy assessment.*

The proof, already delivered. Nine engagements, all filed with reasoning intact

Client	Decision	Outcome
Stargas	Enter cylinder testing?	Deep dive, top five supply opportunities, grant aid, branded one-pager
United Hardware	Form a paint buying group?	Validation brief, verification pack, location addendum, formal response to Candon's review
United Hardware	Buy a standalone garden centre?	Recommendation against, with reasoning
United Hardware ARC	Is the 2025 audit sound?	Audit review, Data Transformation board paper, Vendor Challenge Brief
Arcade Trader	What is it worth, how do we build value?	Four-domain report, growth model and economics, investment and value-building, full seven-manager report
Fleming Medical	Ready for a capital event?	Seven-domain analysis. Corrected an earlier optimistic scoring, found value concentrated in three obscured segments, recommended 18 to 24 months of structural work first, closed with five questions the board must answer
Barber Republic	What instrument for Ed Lawton's £50k?	Funding ladder, dilution modelling, two scenarios, rollout roadmap. Converged independently with Shane's own founder documents
Export Anatolia	How do we adopt AI?	Seven-manager briefing (<i>note: this one belongs to Velocity</i>)
UroPharma / Mike Molloy	Is this real, should John back it?	Preliminary then verified assessment. Recommended hold pending proof

Eight of the nine are decision briefs. One, Export Anatolia, is an AI adoption job that should have gone to Velocity. That is the only misplacement in the book, and it is instructive.

VELOCITY AI — THE DEFINITION

What it is. The operator. Shane's brand. Builds and deploys AI at scale, in the client's business, alongside the client's team.

Its own words, verified from velocityai.ie: “We are not consultants. We are operators who build and deploy AI at scale.” “We diagnose where AI will hit your business first, then we build the response.”

The offer, verified from the EDelia proposal, June 2026. Phase One, AI-Native Readiness, three months, €30,000 + VAT at €10,000 per month: orchestration engines embedded across the client’s core team, two to three proprietary proof points built and branded for the client, a governance baseline, five team sessions and two CEO sessions, readiness diagnostics. Phase Two, AI-Native Build, full architecture and company-wide integration, costed at the end of Phase One.

Live front-of-site tools: Strategic Clarity Diagnostic, Live Strategic Simulator, 90-Second Strategic Brief. Four tiers of Migration Education: Leadership Teams, 1-to-1 Decision Makers, Board Advisory, Senior Management.

Where it sits against Meridian. Velocity is downstream of a decision already made. The client has decided AI is the answer and needs it built. Meridian is upstream, at the moment the decision itself is still open, and usually about something other than AI.

The genuine overlap, and it is narrow. Velocity leads on the word “clarity” and on “we diagnose.” That brushes against Meridian. But Velocity diagnoses *where AI will hit the business*. Meridian diagnoses *whether to do the deal*. Same verb, different object.

AMBRION AI — THE DEFINITION

Verified from the Ambrion AI Briefing Note prepared for this session, 5 August 2026.

What it is. An Irish intelligence and advisory firm specialising in AI strategy, architecture and governance. Founded by Shane McCarthy (CEO, Founder, AI Architect, Systems Builder) and John Webb O’Rourke (commercial and governance lead). Ambrion helps organisations integrate AI into their foundational operating models rather than treating it as a superficial add-on.

Three core beliefs

- **Built-in, not bolt-on.** AI must be designed into an organisation’s core data pipelines, decision rights and workflows, not added as an extra software tool.
- **Governance as an enabler.** Proper governance provides the safety rails and accountability required to scale AI safely without risking client trust or data integrity.
- **Human judgment.** Systems propose options and patterns. Humans retain final decision-making authority.

Current commercial focus. A tiered, done-for-you EU AI Act compliance offering for Irish SMEs, positioned deliberately against software-only compliance platforms. The EU AI Act applies in full from 2 August 2026, which makes this immediately live and time-critical.

Route to market. The Smacht network, roughly 300 Irish SMEs, via Padraic O’Maille. Professional referral partners, specifically accountants and solicitors. The United Hardware senior executive AI training programme, with a second course being scheduled for August 2026.

Live opportunity. Oifig IS na hEireann, the AI Office of Ireland, launched this week as Ireland’s independent central coordinating authority for EU AI Act implementation, led by CEO Paul Byrne alongside Ministers Peter Burke and Niamh Smyth. The Office has explicitly flagged stakeholder engagement as a priority. This is a genuine opening for Ambrion as a practitioner voice rather than a cold approach. John and Shane are exploring LinkedIn engagement followed by a direct introduction.

Status. Highest priority revenue stream. The 2 August 2026 anchor is **now active**, not passed: it was the compliance campaign launch date. Live outreach in progress, including Glennon Brothers.
Ambrion is John's primary revenue vehicle for the next three years.

Where it sits against Meridian. Ambrion answers "the law now applies to us, are we compliant." Meridian answers "should we do this." Ambrion's buyer is compelled by regulation. Meridian's buyer is choosing. Ambrion sells a programme with a statutory driver behind it. Meridian sells a single answer to a single question.

The one remaining UNCONFIRMED item: the ownership split. Meridian's (John 70 / Shane 30) and Velocity's (Shane 70 / John 30) are on the record. Ambrion's is not. Given it is named as John's primary revenue vehicle for three years, this should be documented before anything else in the portfolio is formalised.

WHERE THEY COLLIDE, AND THE FIX

Three collisions. All three are fixable and none of them are structural.

Collision one, and it is inside Meridian's own materials

Meridian's current pricing sheet sells three products, and all three are AI services: AI in Plain English (€4,875 / €6,500), AI Governance Readiness Assessment (€9,000 / €12,000), AI Readiness Accelerator (€13,500 / €18,000). That is Ambrion's pillar one and Velocity's core offer, priced under Meridian's name, and it is the opposite of what Meridian delivered in eight of its nine engagements.

Fix: those three products move to Ambrion, and the Ambrion briefing settles it beyond argument. Ambrion's live campaign is a tiered done-for-you EU AI Act compliance offering for Irish SMEs. An AI Governance Readiness Assessment is not merely adjacent to that, it is a tier of it. AI in Plain English is the natural top-of-funnel for the Smacht network and the accountant and solicitor channel. The AI Readiness Accelerator is the delivery tier. Three products sitting under the wrong brand, with a ready-built route to market waiting for them under the right one.

Collision two: Meridian's Manager 5, AI Strategy and Adoption

As written it claims AI governance frameworks, EU AI Act compliance, readiness assessments and adoption roadmaps. Every one of those is Ambrion or Velocity.

Fix: Manager 5 stays in the engine, comes off the shopfront. Meridian keeps the domain because decisions sometimes touch AI and the analysis needs it. Meridian stops selling it. Export Anatolia-shaped enquiries route to Velocity.

Collision three: board and governance advisory is claimed three times

Ambrion (Board and Executive Advisory), Meridian (Manager 2, Legal and Governance), Velocity (Board Advisory, The Governance Foundation). A single client could meet all three at the same door.

Fix: Ambrion owns board AI governance outright, and the briefing makes this the obvious answer. Ambrion is the EU AI Act vehicle with a statutory driver, a live campaign, a named channel and a direct line forming to the AI Office of Ireland. Nothing else in the portfolio should reach for that ground. Meridian's Manager 2 is scoped to governance inside a decision (directors' duties on this transaction, is this audit sound, what is our exposure if we do this). Velocity drops Board Advisory from its education tiers, or renames it to build-side governance. This one needs Shane's agreement and is the hardest of the three.

THE REFERRAL FLOW — THE OVERLAP TURNED INTO A CHANNEL

Once the three doors are separate, each one feeds the others. This is worth money and should be formalised with an agreed fee split.

- **Meridian to Velocity.** Meridian sits with owners at the moment of a commercial decision. That room throws off AI need constantly. Every Export Anatolia is a Velocity job introduced at zero acquisition cost.
- **Meridian to Ambrion, and this is the important one.** Ambrion is John's primary revenue vehicle for the next three years. Meridian sits with owners and boards at the moment of a major decision, which is precisely the moment an EU AI Act exposure becomes visible and uncomfortable. Fleming Medical's five board questions are an Ambrion opening. **Meridian's highest-value output may not be its own fee. It is qualified, warm, board-level access for Ambrion at the moment the buyer is most receptive.**

- **Velocity to Meridian.** A client mid-AI-programme hits a commercial, structural or investment decision. Velocity does not sell that. Meridian does.
- **Ambrion to Meridian.** A board that has just had its AI compliance handled is a board that trusts the same people with its next real decision. The Smacht network alone is roughly 300 Irish SMEs, and the accountant and solicitor referral partners are exactly the professionals who see a client's big decisions coming before anyone else does.

Three brands, one ecosystem, no cannibalisation. That is the answer to Shane's "two people talking about the same thing."

The portfolio order, now that the briefing is in

Ambrion is stated in its own briefing as John's primary revenue vehicle for the next three years, with a statutory deadline behind it and a live campaign running. **That settles the priority question, and Meridian's business case has to be built inside it, not alongside it.**

Meridian is not competing for that first position and should not be positioned as if it were. Meridian earns its place three ways: it is the only vehicle that reaches a buyer who is not thinking about AI, it generates fee revenue on days rather than months, and it feeds the primary vehicle warm board-level introductions at the exact moment of receptiveness. That is a strong argument for building Meridian properly, and a poor argument for launching it ahead of Ambrion's compliance campaign.

THE MERIDIAN BUSINESS CASE

Expanded against Shane's four questions.

1 WHAT IT IS

Meridian is an executive intelligence practice. Its product is the decision brief: one high-consequence business decision, answered with a written, decision-grade position in days, using seven senior domains run simultaneously with forty years of board judgment as the final gate. Not a report. Not a slide deck. A position, with the reasoning attached and the unknowns named.

Note the shape of the sentence, because it is the whole argument. *Practice* is what it is. *The decision brief* is what it sells. AI appears in neither, and that is deliberate.

2 WHO IT IS FOR

Owners, chairs and boards of Irish and UK mid-market businesses, roughly €5m to €100m turnover, facing a decision worth at least two orders of magnitude more than the fee, in one of the four situations above.

The qualifying question is a single sentence: is there a decision on your desk right now that is too expensive to get wrong and too broad for any one adviser?

3 HOW IT MAKES MONEY

Line one, the decision brief. Proven nine times. One decision, defined scope, written deliverable, days not weeks. It prices as a unit because it has a boundary. Indicative €3,000 to €15,000 depending on domains engaged and stakes. *Indicative only, to be set by John.*

Line two, the retained decision seat. United Hardware is already this shape without being named as such: multiple decisions across a year, one board, standing access. This is where the durable revenue is because it removes the sell each time. Indicative €4,000 to €8,000 per month covering an agreed brief count plus standing availability. *Indicative only.*

Line three, AI equity and investment (Manager 7). AI capability contributed for equity. Genuinely differentiated, already written into the manager set, and the line that turns Meridian from a fee business into an asset business. Slowest to convert, hardest to sell cold. Treat as line three, not line one.

Funding offsets already identified: Skillnet Ireland, Enterprise Ireland Innovation Vouchers up to €5,000.

4 WHAT IS DEFENSIBLE, AND WHERE THE AI EXPERTISE ACTUALLY SITS

*The rarity is not that Meridian knows about AI. It is that Meridian has **built and operates a governed multi-domain AI intelligence engine, and a serving PLC chair signs its output.** Almost nobody has both halves.*

Layer one: the parallel-domain method

Seven senior domains interrogated simultaneously over the same question, then consolidated into one position. Fleming Medical is the proof: seven domains, eight to ten interrogated questions each, consolidated into an executive brief with five risks, a four-programme recommendation and a human gate. A traditional firm takes weeks and charges multiples. Real advantage today, eroding over eighteen to thirty-six months as others build similar engines. Time-limited, so do not build the whole case on it.

Layer two, and this is the rare one: the verification discipline

Every AI-generated claim is checked against source and labelled verified, estimated or unverified before it reaches a client. Nothing unsourced. Nothing presented as fact that is not. This is already the standing rule and it is visible in the work: the Mike Molloy assessment was held pending proof rather than sold as verified; the Fleming Medical brief corrected Meridian's own earlier optimistic scoring; the Export Anatolia sector description was corrected on record from castings to agricultural machinery parts.

*The market is about to be flooded with confident, plausible, unverifiable AI analysis. Meridian's product is analysis a board can rely on and a director can sign against. **The discipline is the product. The AI is the engine.***

Very few will have this because it is expensive and unglamorous. It requires someone who knows what a board will not accept, and who is willing to slow the machine down and mark a claim unverified when it would read better as fact. That is a governance instinct, not a technical one, and it comes from forty years of sitting where the liability lands.

Layer three: access that cannot be copied

John chairs AHL PLC. He is Independent Non-Executive Director and Chair of the Audit and Risk Committee at United Hardware. Four decades of board relationships across commercial, property, healthcare, governance and capital. This is why Meridian is in the room where the decision is made, not the room where a report is received. A competitor can copy the method in a year. They cannot copy forty years of being trusted by the people who own the decision.

Layer four, the compounding one: the corpus

Nine engagements are filed with their reasoning intact, and every new one adds a decision pattern to a body of Irish and UK mid-market precedent that only Meridian holds. Barber Republic proved its worth directly: Meridian's analysis and Shane's independently written founder documents converged on the same instrument, and that convergence is what gave the recommendation its authority. In three years this corpus is the asset, and it is what makes Meridian saleable rather than merely billable.

5 CAPACITY

The product is a fixed-scope written brief, not open-ended advisory days. The engine does production. John does review and judgment. That is a far higher ceiling than a conventional practice, and it is raised by adding senior reviewers who pressure-test a brief, not by finding another cross-disciplinary synthesiser. Realistic today alongside existing board commitments: **eight to twelve briefs a month**. At line-one pricing that is a real business before a single retainer is signed.

6 WHAT MUST CHANGE, IN ORDER

1. **Move the three AI products to Ambrion.** Meridian's price list becomes the decision brief and the retained seat.
2. **Take Manager 5 off the shopfront.** Keep it in the engine.
3. **Stop leading on "clarity" and "strategic intelligence."** Velocity owns that ground and owns it first. Meridian leads on the decision.
4. **Settle board governance ownership with Shane.** Ambrion owns it. Meridian's Manager 2 is scoped to governance inside a decision.
5. **Formalise the three-way referral with a fee split.**

6. **Draw the Meridian 70/30 shareholders agreement, and document Ambrion's split.** Meridian's is undrawn. Ambrion's is not even on the record, and it is the vehicle named as John's primary revenue source for three years. That is the more urgent of the two.
7. **Then launch, and launch on the nine.** Real anonymised engagements, not staged samples of unnamed businesses. *"A gas distributor asked whether to enter cylinder testing. Here is how it was answered in six days."* That is the proof Shane asked for and it is already owned. Seek permission to name Stargas, Arcade Trader and Fleming Medical. Handle United Hardware carefully given the board position.

7 TEST TARGETS OFFERED BY JOHN, 5 AUGUST 2026

Primeline Logistics, Vinny Leonard, DSB Accountants. All three are live-fire tests of the decision brief in front of real businesses, which is precisely what Shane asked for. Vinny is already warm through Fleming Medical. **Run these after the definition above is agreed, not before**, so each one proves the proposition rather than adding another undefined engagement to the book.

DSB Accountants is a double play and should be run deliberately as one. Ambrion's stated referral channel is accountants and solicitors. So DSB is simultaneously a Meridian decision-brief prospect and an Ambrion referral-partner prospect. Approach it as one conversation with two doors: Meridian demonstrates the calibre of thinking on a live decision, and that same demonstration is the credential that makes DSB comfortable referring its own client base into Ambrion's EU AI Act offering. That is the referral flow above, proven on a single account.

THE FIVE SENTENCES

What it is. *Meridian is an executive intelligence practice. It takes one high-consequence business decision and returns a written, decision-grade position in days, using seven senior domains run simultaneously with forty years of board judgment as the final gate.*

Who it is for. *Owners, chairs and boards of Irish and UK mid-market businesses facing a capital event, an expansion move, a governance question with teeth, or a proposition that needs verifying before it is backed.*

How it makes money. *Fixed-scope decision briefs, retained decision seats, and AI-for-equity structures.*

Why it is defensible. *A verification discipline almost nobody will match, board-level access nobody can copy, and a compounding corpus of decision precedent only Meridian holds.*

How it differs. *Ambrion makes you compliant. Velocity makes you capable. Meridian makes the call. Ambrion's buyer is compelled by law, Velocity's has already chosen AI, and Meridian's is not thinking about AI at all.*

Meridian Intelligence · Definition and business case · 5 August 2026 · Private and confidential. Every Meridian claim is drawn from delivered work filed in the Meridian repository. Velocity positioning verified from velocityai.ie and the EDelia proposal, June 2026. Ambrion verified from the Ambrion AI Briefing Note, 5 August 2026. Ambrion ownership split remains UNCONFIRMED. Meridian pricing marked indicative is not yet set.